

The Hansard

A WEEKLY DIGEST OF THE PROCEEDINGS OF THE PARLIAMENT OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

The murder of Ann Widdecombe

The week began in mourning. On Monday 13 July, before the day's business, the Speaker told the House that Ann Widdecombe — Member of Parliament for Maidstone from 1987 to 2010, and latterly a figure in Reform UK — had died “in tragic, deeply troubling circumstances,” and the Home Secretary made it plain: “On

Wednesday, Ann Widdecombe was murdered in her home.” Counter Terrorism Policing is leading the investigation; a 28-year-old man is in custody, not known to Prevent; no motive has been established. Tributes ran across three days and both Houses, and at Prime Minister's Questions Sir Keir Starmer called it “chilling” that three serving or

former Members have been murdered in his eleven years in Parliament. Around the mourning, a heavy legislative week: the Hillsborough Law through the Commons, a flagship immigration Bill given its Second Reading, and a valedictory air about the Prime Minister himself.

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST

Town and Country Planning (Discharge of Lo...		283–182
Immigration and Asylum Bill: Second Reading		264–90
Supply of Machinery (Safety) Regulations		317–103
Public Office (Accountability) Bill, Report Stage:...		93–323
Immigration and Asylum Bill: Reasoned...		97–358
Children's Wellbeing and Schools Act 202...		369–102
Public Office (Accountability) Bill, Report Stag...		102–409
Public Office (Accountability) Bill, Report Stag...		104–412

THE WEEK IN BRIEF

Tributes to Ann Widdecombe, 13 to 15 July. The Speaker and the Home Secretary led tributes in the Commons, the Lords followed on Tuesday, and the Prime Minister spoke at Prime Minister's Questions. The Home Secretary confirmed that Counter Terrorism Policing leads the investigation and announced a review by Sir Robert Buckland of the lessons of the Sir David Amess murder.

The Hillsborough Law, 14 July. The Public Office (Accountability) Bill passed the Commons on the night of 14 July, imposing a duty of candour on public officials. Three amendments at report stage were defeated by 412 votes to 104, 409 to 102, and 323 to 93.

Immigration and Asylum Bill, 13 July. The Government's borders Bill was given a second reading by 264 votes to 90. A reasoned amendment to refuse it a second reading fell first by 358 votes to 97. The Bill is now in committee.

Prime Minister's Questions, 15 July. Sir Keir Starmer took what looked like one of his final sessions at the Dispatch Box before a handover. Andy Burnham, returned to the Commons last month as the Member for Makerfield, is the expected successor.

WRITTEN QUESTIONS, BY DEPARTMENT

Defence	293
Health	292
Transport	174
Housing	164
Home Office	162
Environment	131
Education	125
Cabinet Office	121
17 others	675

THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

16 Defence: Finance · 13 RAF Barnham · 10 Asylum: MOD Bicester · 10 Asylum: Age Assurance · 9 Pigs: Animal Housing · 9 Visitor Levy · 8 Defence: Artificial Intelligence · 8 Housing: Sales · 8 Food: Salt · 7 Artificial Intelligence: Laboratories

THE FEATURE

RAF Barnham

Rupert Lowe, the Restore Britain Member for Great Yarmouth, tabled twelve written questions on RAF Barnham, a former Ministry of Defence site now being turned

into asylum accommodation. He pressed on the contractor budget, freedom of movement, safeguarding for female residents, and the cost of one day restoring the site.

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK'S QUESTIONS

Asylum: MOD Bicester

Calum Miller, Liberal Democrat

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, whether the Government intends to use a Crown Development Order in relation to proposals to use Site A at MoD Bicester for asylum accommodation.

THE ANSWER The Home Office has submitted an application for Urgent Crown Development for the proposed large site at Bicester. It is important to note that although the Home Office has submitted a planning application to obtain suitable planning permission, no final decision has been made or will be made until all relevant due diligence, including planning, has been completed and considered.

THE MOST ACTIVE

Mike Wood asked more written questions than any other Member of Parliament this week with 90.

Luke Pollard answered the most with 182.